HAPPINESS MANTRA

"I am driven to spread happiness. Art and creativity are in the blood of Kashmiris. What they lack is exposure. I am acting as that bridge"

DEEPA SONI, Artist and fashion designer

hama—woven with the help of eyeless needles called *kani* or *tuzhi*. Woven on handlooms, Kani shawl-making is a long, laborious process that not only requires immense skill but also infinite patience, with a single stole taking six months to a year or two to make. The design script itself is an intricate code, a 'taleem' drawn on paper that is decipherable only by the weaver. Over the years, however, the lack of a skilled workforce, exploitative middlemen and competition from cheaper, machine-made products have left the craftsmen disheartened.

Soni's workshops, therefore, are serving as the last hope for the 'last generation of craftspersons'. "The last generation is not passing their craft or skills to their offspring," she says. "They want them to be doctors, engineers—anything but craftspersons." The oldest family of Kani shawl weavers—the Sant Kabir Award-winning Mirs of Natipora in Srinagar—is all praise for Soni. Majid Ahmad Mir, a fifth-generation artisan who has a master's in economics and political science from Kashmir University and IGNOU, had long lamented the prospect of the craft of his forefathers disappearing into the pages of history. Soni's interventions, he says, have given it a new lease of life. He recalls



DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

ONE-MAN ARMY Sushanta Giri, on a boat in one of the many creeks that cut through the Sundarbans

Helping Hand on the Sundarbans

***Happiness delivery:** Baikunthapur Tarun Sangha helps people in the Sundarbans' remote coastal villages battle grim lives by taking care of their basic needs*

By **ROMITA DATTA**